

bass drops have depth and weight, but they do not hit aggressively. This works well for long sessions and modern R&B, but bass lovers may find it slightly soft compared to some options out there.

The midrange is where these earbuds shine. Vocals sound natural and forward without becoming shouty. This tuning works well for podcasts, calls, and Indian music where vocals carry emotional weight.

Treble is relaxed. There is no harshness, but also no sparkle. Cymbals and high-frequency textures sit in the background. This makes poor recordings easier to tolerate, but listeners who enjoy crisp detail may find it a bit dull.

Spatial Audio is available, but only when paired with compatible Pixel phones for supported content. In real-world use, it adds a mild sense of depth and is good for occasional fun.

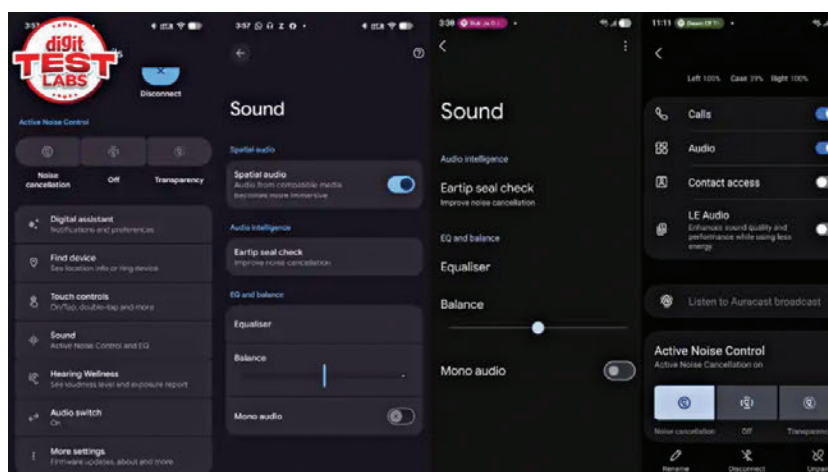
ANC AND CALL QUALITY

Active noise cancellation is present, though it isn't tuned to block out everything around you. In an office setting,



softer sounds like murmurs, keyboard taps, and background chatter can still be heard to some extent, and on busy streets, sharper noises such as horns and whistles do come through.

Once music starts playing, however, the ANC feels far more effective for everyday use. Low-frequency sounds like engine hum and road rumble are reduced well, making daily commutes more comfortable. Running the Ear Seal Check in the app also helps improve consistency and is worth doing, especially after switching ear tips.



Transparency mode works reliably too. Voices sound natural with very little artificial processing, which makes it feel safe to use while walking outdoors, an important consideration in Indian traffic conditions.

Call quality is consistent across devices. On non-Pixel phones, calls sounded clear on both ends with no noticeable issues. Paired with a Pixel 8 or newer phone, features like Super Wideband and Clear Calling add an extra layer of clarity, making calls sound a bit cleaner and more focused.

BATTERY LIFE AND CHARGING

Battery life is solid for everyday use, even if it isn't class-leading. With ANC on, using the AAC codec and volume set at around 80%, the Pixel Buds 2a lasted close to 8 hours and 45 minutes in my testing. That comfortably beats Google's own conservative claims, though there are rivals in this segment, such as the Galaxy Buds 3 FE, that manage longer runtimes.

A quick top-up is useful too. Around five minutes of charging is said to deliver roughly an hour of listening, while a full charge takes about two hours. Wireless charging isn't supported, which some buyers may miss at this price, especially given how common it has become in this segment.

VERDICT

The Pixel Buds 2a reflect what the Pixel lineup has always stood for: a clean,

low-friction experience that prioritises essential features and usability. The earbuds are light, the case is chic and compact, and together they feel genuinely portable and comfortable. Their strengths fall into three layers. You get the must-haves like responsive touch controls, reliable call quality, accurate wear detection, and stable Bluetooth multipoint. Then there are the good-to-have features, such as Audio Switch and hands-free Google or Gemini Assistant. On top of that sit a few Pixel-only extras like Spatial Audio that add polish if you are inside Google's ecosystem.

What the Pixel Buds 2a do well becomes clearer once you live with them for a while. The sound tuning is easy-going and works well for long sessions. ANC and transparency are not class-leading, but consistent and effective for everyday commutes and office use.

—G. S. Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Google Tensor A1 | Earbud: 11 mm Dynamic speaker driver | Case IP rating: IPX4 | Earbuds IP rating: IP54 | Connectivity: Bluetooth 5.4 | ANC: Silent Seal 1.5 with Transparency mode | Sensors: 2 Microphones | Charging: USB-C | Buds Battery: 10 Hrs without ANC

CONTACT

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tinyurl.com/8hq01j